

Software Project Documentation

Fundamentals: Documentation Types, Target Audiences, Standards & Culture

Course:	SW Project Documentation (15-Week Course)	Instructor:	Ph.D. Batnyam Battulga
Institution:	National University of Mongolia (SoSe 2026)	Format:	Seminar (90 Min Lecture + 90 Min Lab/Exercise)
Status Date:	August 30, 2026	Evaluation:	Mandatory Milestone M1 Track

🎯 SPRINT GOAL (WEEK 01)

Students will distinguish the **four documentation types** (Chinchilla Ch. 2), define their target audience using a concrete **Persona Profile** (Bhatti Ch. 1), identify the **"Curse of Knowledge"** (Bhatti p. 3) in three real repositories, and conduct a **"Writer-in-the-Middle" self-analysis** (Chinchilla p. 5).

PRODUCT BACKLOG (USER STORIES & TASKS)

US-1.1: Categorize Documentation Types in Real Repositories

[Chinchilla Ch. 2](#)

As a student, I want to map the four documentation types (Getting Started, Tutorial, Reference, API) across real open-source projects (e.g., Stripe, MDN, FastAPI, NumPy), so that I can make structured documentation decisions for future projects.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA (GIVEN-WHEN-THEN):

- Categorize at least three real-world repositories into a complete set of the 4 documentation types.
- Provide 2 sentences per type detailing: (1) Typical user query answered, and (2) Typical location/file path.
- Publish the complete mapping matrix as a wiki page in the Confluence course workspace.

 **Literature Anchor:** Chinchilla Ch. 2 "Understanding Different Types of Documentation" (pp. 9–24). Specifics: Getting Started (pp. 10–12), Tutorials (pp. 12–14), Reference (pp. 15–17), API Docs (pp. 18–22).

US-1.2: Construct an Audience Persona Card for Master Project

[Bhatti Ch. 1](#)

As a student, I want to create a detailed Persona Card for my master project based on Bhatti Ch. 1 (pp. 15–16), so that I have a specific, human counterpart in mind during writing rather than addressing a generic "everyone".

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA (GIVEN-WHEN-THEN):

- Persona includes: First Name, Fictional Company, Technical Role, and Daily Toolstack.
- Identify 3 concrete developer pain points sourced from real community feedback (Sentry, StackOverflow, Slack).
- Include 1 realistic, constructed quote reflecting a key user frustration from a 30-minute interview session.

 **Literature Anchor:** Bhatti Ch. 1 "Understanding Your Audience" (pp. 1–21); Persona creation (p. 15), User Stories (p. 16), User Journey Maps (p. 17). Corg.ly Case Study (pp. 1–2: Charlotte & Launch deadline).

US-1.3: Perform "Curse of Knowledge" Self-Audit on Project README

[Bhatti p. 3](#)

As a student, I want to run a "Curse of Knowledge" audit on my repository's README by testing 3 sentences on a non-engineer, so that I can uncover hidden assumptions about reader background knowledge.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA (GIVEN-WHEN-THEN):

- Highlight at least 3 original sentences flagged as "Jargon-only" or overly opaque.
- Rewrite at least 1 sentence applying the "Most Important Information First" rule with a concrete example (Bhatti p. 58).
- Publish a Before/After Diff comparison in the course workspace.

 **Literature Anchor:** Bhatti Ch. 1 (p. 3) "The Curse of Knowledge" (citing Newton 1990; Camerer et al. 1989). Writing Guidelines: Bhatti Ch. 3 (p. 58) "State your most important information first".

US-1.4: "Writer-in-the-Middle" Team Value Proposition (200 Words)

Chinchilla Ch. 1

As a student, I want to write a 200-word response to "What value can I deliver as a documentation author in a software team?", so that I can advocate for documentation value during sprint planning.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA (GIVEN-WHEN-THEN):

- Detail 7 spheres of impact (Marketing, Product, Sales, Support, DevRel, Engineering, Machine Readers) with 1 project example each.
- Demonstrate an understanding of the "Writer-in-the-Middle" role (Chinchilla p. 5).
- Incorporate "End-End Users" into the persona definition (Chinchilla p. 7).

 **Literature Anchor:** Chinchilla Ch. 1 (pp. 1–8). Key concepts: "Why care about tech writing?" (p. 1), "What can documentarians accomplish?" (pp. 2–3), "Writer in the middle" (p. 5), "End users vs. End-end users" (p. 7).

DEFINITION OF DONE (SPRINT CHECKLIST)

Status	Deliverable Item	Verification & Acceptance Criteria	Workspace Link
☐	4 Doc-Types Matrix	Mapping table for 3 open-source repos categorized across 4 types with Q&A context.	/wiki/doc-types
☐	Audience Persona Card	Published persona profile (Name, Role, Tools, 3 Pain Points, 1 Interview Quote).	/wiki/personas
☐	Curse of Knowledge Diff	3 flagged jargon sentences + Before/After rewritten diff with concrete examples.	/wiki/curse-diff
☐	Writer-in-the-Middle Analysis	200-word essay covering the 7 spheres of impact and end-end user alignment.	/wiki/writer-role
☐	Week 01 Concept Quiz	Online quiz testing Week 01 literature concepts passed with score ≥ 80%.	LMS Platform

MANDATORY LITERATURE LAB EXERCISE (UE-1 • 90 MIN)

 Lab Task: Corg.ly Case Study Roleplay MANDATORY SUBMISSION

Scenario: Step into the shoes of *Charlotte* from Bhatti's Corg.ly Case Study (pp. 1–2), who is preparing for the launch of the *Pet Translation API*.

Deliverables (Single Markdown Document in Workspace, max 4 pages):

1. **Part A: Persona Card** according to Bhatti pp. 15–16 for the Pet Translation API target developer.
2. **Part B: Curse-of-Knowledge Audit** on 3 Corg.ly API README sentences following Bhatti p. 3.
3. **Part C: Writer-in-the-Middle Reflection** applying Chinchilla p. 5 to Charlotte's launch position.

Grading Rubric: Concrete Detail of Persona Profile (40%) • Jargon Reduction Quality in Diff (40%) • Depth of Critical Self-Reflection (20%).

AGILE TEAM RITUALS

 Daily Standup (3 Questions)

1. Which 3 open-source repos did I categorize into documentation types today?
2. What is the current progress on my Persona Card (Data, Quote, Toolstack)?
3. Which specific jargon sentence from my README did I rewrite today?

 Sprint Retrospective (3 Questions)

1. **What went well?** (e.g., Applying Chinchilla's 4-type split vs. gut feeling)
2. **What wasted time?** (e.g., Confluence setup friction vs. actual content)
3. **What will I change next week?** (e.g., Earlier persona validation with peers)

REQUIRED READING & LITERATURE PLAN

Required Source	Coverage & Pages	Focus & Exam Relevance
Bhatti et al. (2021) <i>Docs for Developers</i>	Chapter 1 (pp. 1–21) Chapter 3 (pp. 57–60)	Audience analysis, Curse of Knowledge, writing for skimming. Key for Milestone M3 (SRS).
Chinchilla (2024) <i>Tech Writing for Developers</i>	Chapter 1 (pp. 1–8) Chapter 2 (pp. 9–24)	Why tech writing matters, Writer in the middle, 4 core documentation types. Key for M1 & M2.

WEEKLY REFLECTION QUESTIONS

Reflection 1: Which specific concept from Bhatti et al. challenged your previous documentation habits the most? (Specify page number and concept).

Reflection 2: Which framework or rule from Chinchilla will you continue to apply beyond this course in professional projects? (Specify page number).

Reflection 3: In your master project team, where do you observe the largest gap between "*what textbook documentation standards prescribe*" and "*how software teams actually operate*"?